

PLAY YOUR TOP TRICKS

South opens at the 1-level in a suit; both sides stay quiet at the 2-level.

- 1X — Pass — 2X — Pass — Pass — Pass (North raises South's suit; S declares)
- 1X — Pass — 1Y — Pass — 2Y — Pass — Pass — Pass (North bids new suit, South raises; N declares)

Y is always a suit (D/H/S, never NT). NT openings are excluded — the $\text{topTricksNS}=8$ constraint counts tricks in suit-contract terms.

Teaching feature: declarer has enough TOP tricks (sure winners) to make 8 tricks for the contract. The lesson is COUNT FIRST, CASH SECOND — don't get fancy with finesses or unnecessary risks when you already have the tricks you need.

Things to think about:

- Count your AKs and trump length tricks before leading anything.
- If you have 8 top tricks, take them. Don't risk for overtricks unless it's free.
- If you're short of 8 top tricks, then find the ones you're missing — but THIS scenario is designed so you have enough already.
- Watch for entry problems: order your plays so each hand can lead when needed.

Reference: <https://www.bridgebum.com/counting.php>